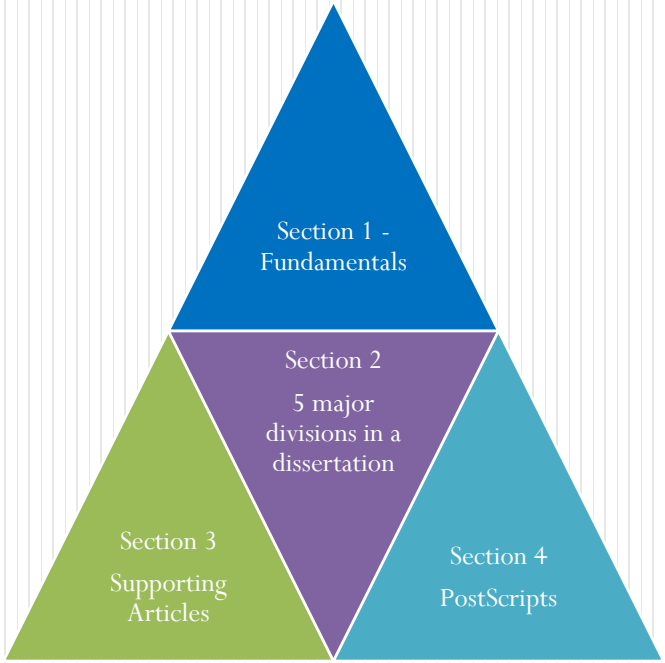
The Dissertation 1

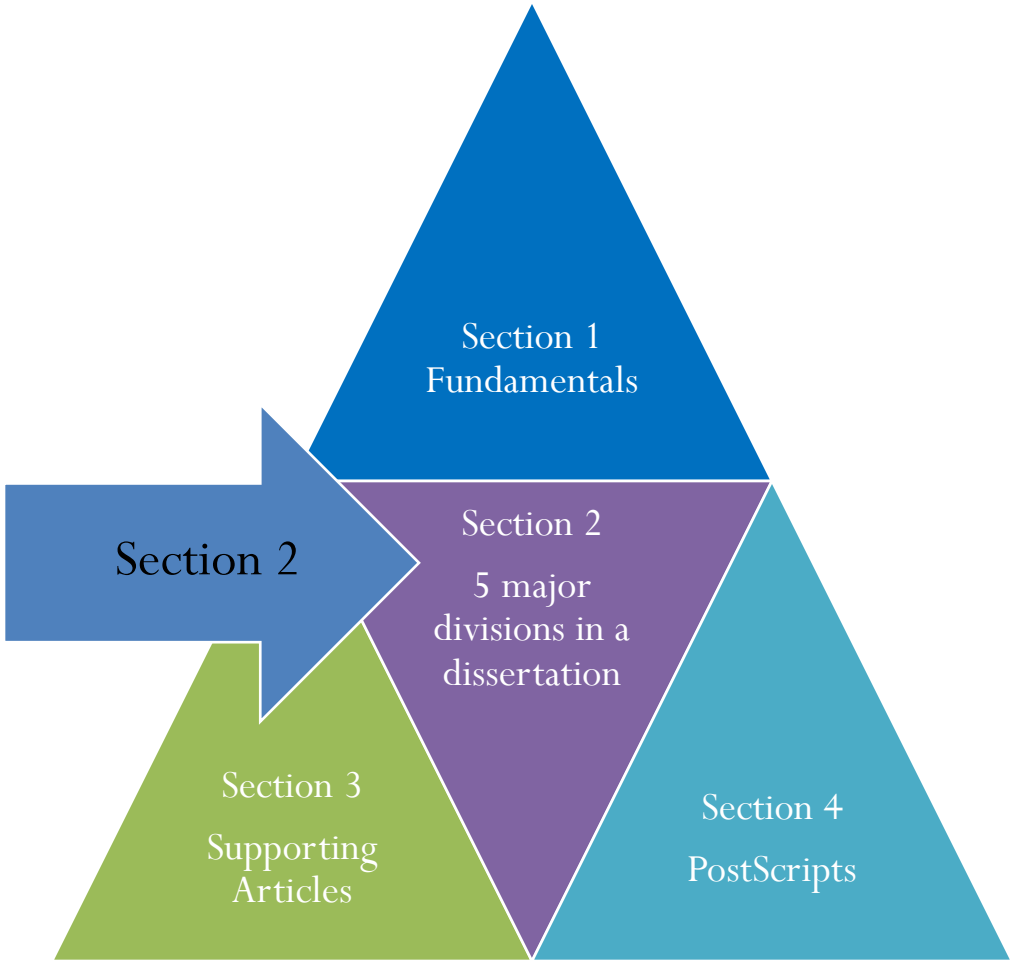
Introduction

Session 2.1



Science starts only with problems – Karl Popper

Different Sections of the Book



Structure of a thesis

Section		Number of chapters
Introduction		Usually one chapter only
Theory		Can be more than one chapter. Structure logical components together.
Research Design		One chapter – although long questionnaire templates may be provided separately in an Appendix.
BODY	Data	What you have found / what you suggest / what you have tested.
	Contribution	What do I contribute from previous section
Conclusion		So – what now?

Introduction

- The introduction Chapter explains to your reader precisely **what** you will do and **why** it's worth doing.
- Work in progress through dissertation writing – should return to your Chapter 1 at the end – thesis is an answer – writing a thesis is a journey.

What belongs in Section 1(Introduction)

- The introduction makes it absolutely clear what your work investigates and the importance of that.
  1. Background information / topic introduction
  2. A problem statement
  3. A thesis statement, Research questions, Research objectives (or purpose of the work)
  4. Delineation and limitations
  5. Definition of terms and concepts (can be an appendix also)
  6. Underlying assumptions.
  7. Significance (or rational for) of the study
  8. Brief chapter overviews

The introduction sets up the criteria by which the reader will judge your work, so losing them here is an absolute guarantee of trouble down the road.

Before section 1.1 Introduction to the Chapter

Remember that each chapter has an introduction and a summary.

- Short introduction to the Thesis and Chapter. Start with "The purpose of this thesis is … or a catching statement.
- Give high-level introduction to what the topic is, go down to what the specific focus is – use the topic graph as guideline.
- What will be discussed in Chapter 1.

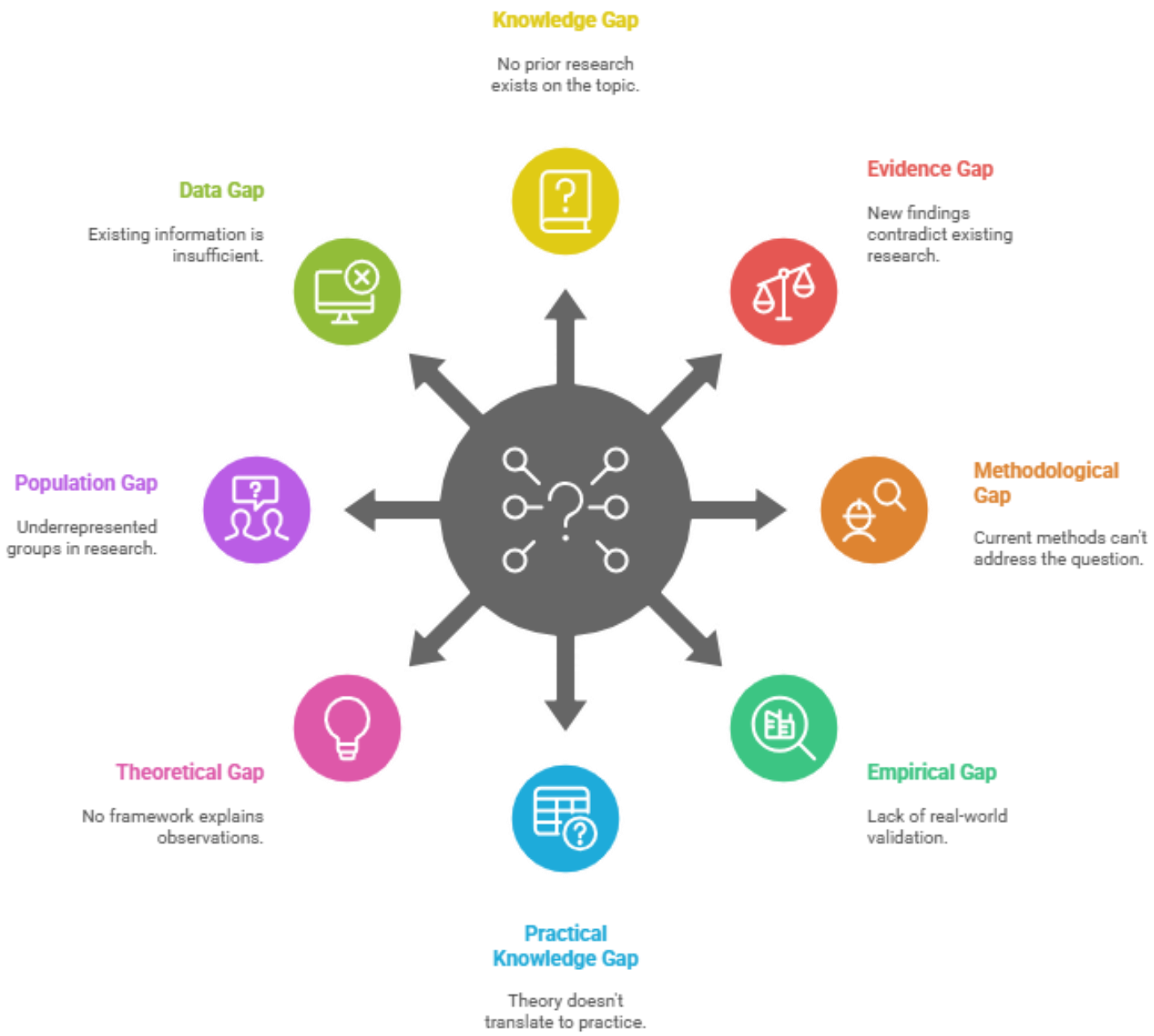
Background Information

- After reading the background information the examiner should have the context of the problem that your work focus on.
- Although you will provide some literature here, it is not a mini-literature review .. If possible, hint at authors that mentioned what you are investigating as being a problem.

Problem Statement

- No dissertation is worth anything without a problem.
- In the problem statement, mention:
  - What is the problem?
  - Why is it a problem?
  - What facets are there to it?
  - What has been done to address it before, if anything, and why is that not satisfactory?
  - Clearly state what is the gap ..The last paragraph of your problem statement must have a sentence that says "The gap in the literature that this study will address …."

Research Gap Types



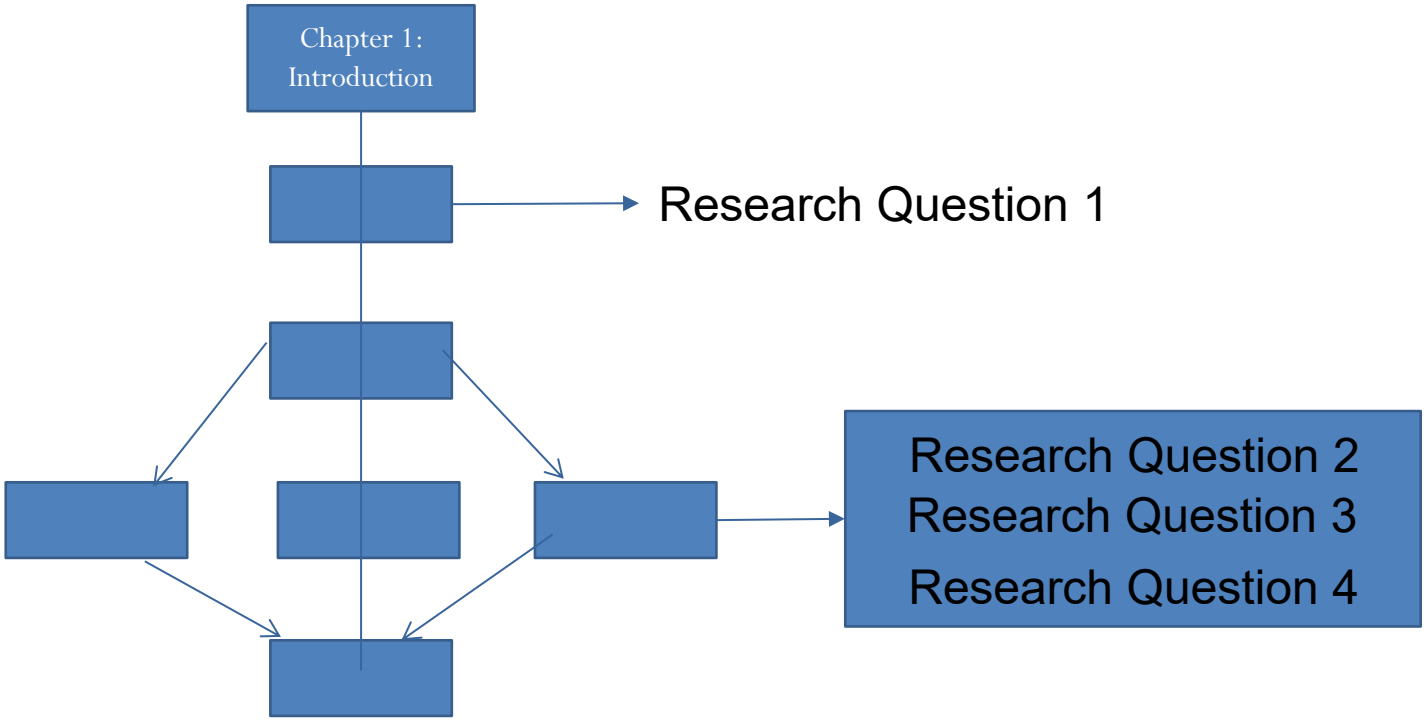
Thesis statements

- The thesis statement tells the reader exactly what you are going to investigate.
- Your thesis statement is what you tell your friends when they ask you what you are studying!
- Write it big, put it against your wall, and keep focus to it.
- Your problem statement, research questions / objectives, and thesis statement should talk to one another.
- After giving your thesis statement, describe it and convince your reader that it makes sense.

- NB: Your main problem should link to your title of your dissertation should link to your main research question or thesis statement.

Research questions

- Use your thesis statement to define your main research question;
- Sub-research questions (Max 2-3)



Research objectives

- After defining your research questions, you need to define your research objectives also. The research objectives should compliment the research questions.
- When an examiner get to the conclusion, he will get back to the research objectives to see if they were met in the research.
- Research objectives should start with To+verb : To illustrate, To establish, To determine, To argue; To prove.

Delineations and Limitations

- Delineations cover your back. They explain to your reader what you will do by also stipulating what you *will not* do.
- Because you limit the scope of your work, the conclusions may not be applicable in certain circumstances or may not address certain relevant issues.
- Limitations will affect how far you can generalize your findings (scope) or how confident you are about your findings (reliability).
- Use sentences such as "This study will not deal with …" or "This work does not consider .. "
- Some limitations may be due to restrictions in your study such as time, money etc.

Assumptions

- Most thesis statements already have some assumptions linked to them.
- Do not be afraid to name the underlying assumptions to your work. It is better to name them than have your examiners name them for you.
- This is mostly the things that you can't control.

Here are two more examples of assumptions in a Business Information Systems (BIS) study:
Technological readiness – It is assumed that the organisations participating in the study have the basic IT infrastructure in place to support the adoption of the system being investigated. Without this baseline, comparisons across organisations wouldn't be meaningful.
Management support – It is assumed that senior managers in the organisations studied are at least somewhat supportive of system adoption. If leadership were completely hostile, then the adoption process would be blocked outright, making it impossible to evaluate the factors under investigation.

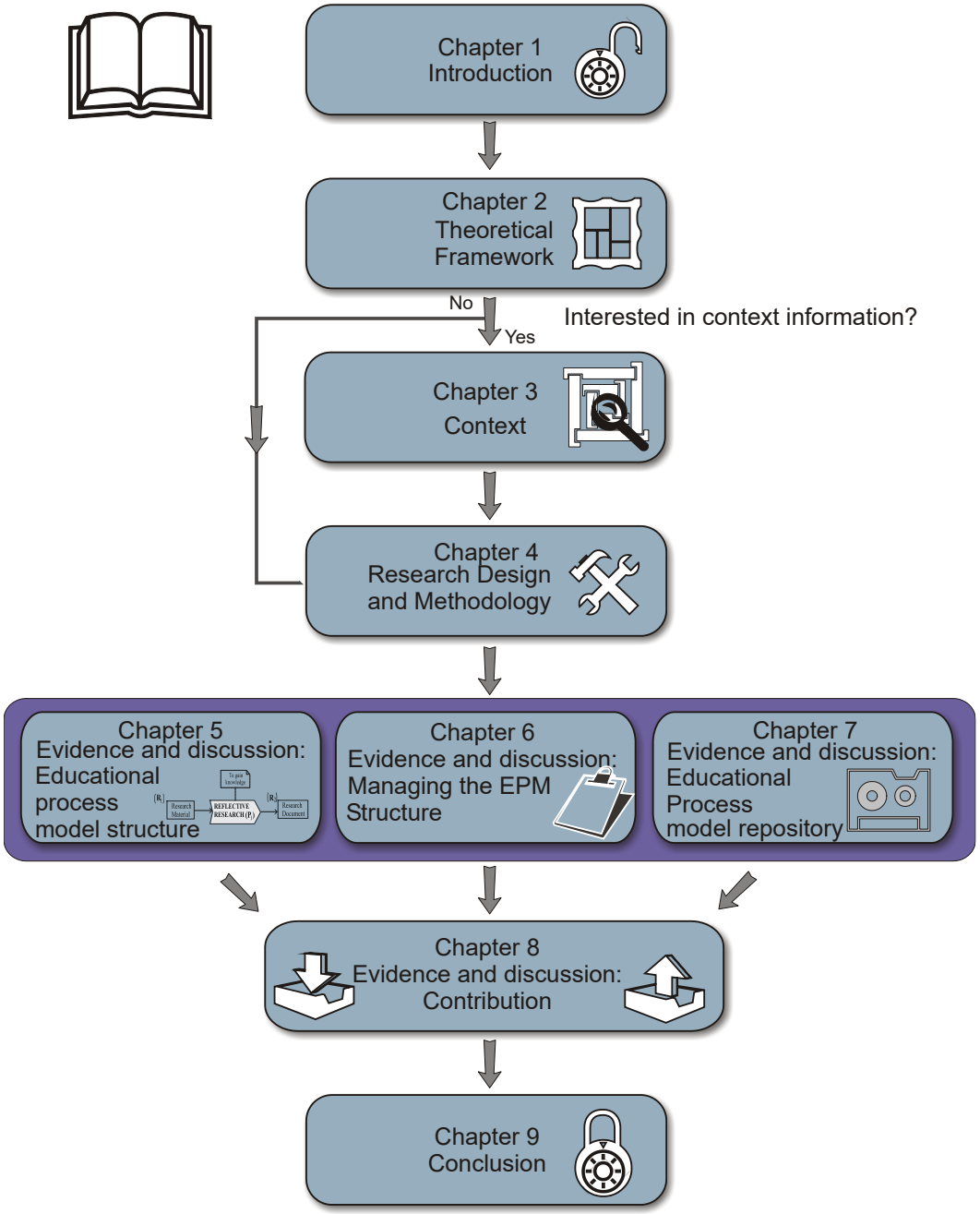
Significance (Rationale)

- Explain why the work is worth doing!
- You can break it into theoretical and practical significance.
- Theoretical: What is your 'theory' that you will contribute?
- Practical: How will your work relate to what is happening in the real world?

Chapter overviews

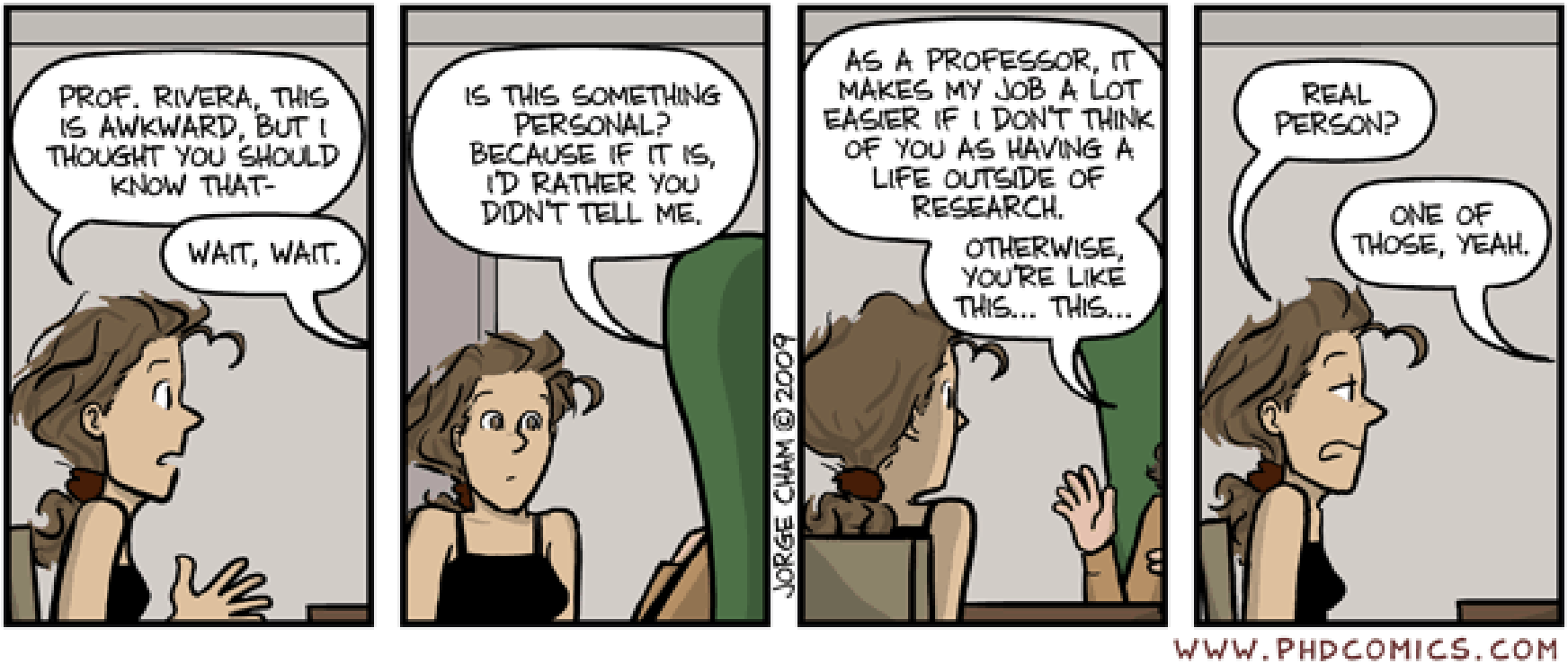
- A **chapter map** in Chapter 1 is like a roadmap for your thesis.
- Its purpose is to give the reader a clear overview of how the rest of the document is structured and what to expect in each chapter.
- By briefly describing the focus of every chapter, it helps the reader understand the logical flow of your research—from introduction and literature review, through methodology and results, to discussion and conclusion.
- Review your chapter map – where will which research question be answered?

Thesis Map



Draw your own Chapter Map at the end of Chapter 1.

10 Minutes



To session 2.2